DIGITALAIKART | INDIA TO JAPAN SERIES

THE JAPAN SSW PLAYBOOK

2026-27 EDITION

The Indian worker's complete guide to Japan's Specified Skilled Worker visa: the language tests, the 19 fields, the real salary, the paperwork, and the agents who take your money.

BUILT FROM OFFICIAL SOURCES ONLY

Immigration Services Agency of Japan (ssw.go.jp, moj.go.jp)
Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare (mhlw.go.jp)
The Japan Foundation | Prometric Japan
Ministry of External Affairs, India | NSDC International
Embassy of Japan in India | Embassy of India, Tokyo

Read this page before anything else

This book is about one thing: how an Indian worker gets to Japan legally, at the lowest honest cost, on Japan's Specified Skilled Worker visa. Every number in it comes from a government publication, a test administrator, or a company's own recruitment notice. Where I could not verify something, I have said so instead of guessing.

Three things you should know about the book before you pay attention to anything else in it.

- **It is a guide, not an agency.** Nobody in this book can get you a visa. Visa decisions belong to Japanese immigration alone. Any person who tells you they can guarantee one is lying, and this book will show you how that lie is usually packaged.
- **Rules move.** Japan rewrote its foreign worker law in 2024 and the new system starts on 1 April 2027. Test fees, minimum wages and visa fees change every year. Everything here was checked against official pages in November 2026. Before you spend money, open the official links in Appendix A and confirm the current position.
- **It will tell you when not to go.** Chapter 7 is a fit test, and it is designed to fail some readers. The visa is a five-year commitment in a country whose language you probably do not speak yet, in work that is physically hard. That is a fine trade for some people and a bad one for others. Both answers are in here.

> **The one number that frames the whole book**
>
> Japan had 425,961 people on the Specified Skilled Worker (i) visa at the end of June 2026. Of those, roughly 600 were Indian. Vietnamese workers alone numbered 176,915. India and Japan signed a plan in August 2025 to send 50,000 skilled people to Japan in five years. The corridor is wide open and almost nobody from India is walking through it - mostly because nobody has told them, accurately, how.

That gap is the reason this book exists. Not because Japan is easy - it is not - but because the information that decides whether you succeed is scattered across Japanese-language government PDFs, a Prometric booking portal and a handful of embassy notices, and the people who have assembled it are mostly agents who charge you for the privilege of hearing it.

A note on currency. This book gives Japanese wages in yen and Indian costs in rupees, and never converts between them. The yen-rupee rate moved by more than a fifth within a single recent year. A guide that prints a conversion rate is a guide that will be wrong by the time you read it. When you need a rupee figure, use the rate on the day you send the money, and treat any agent who quotes you a fixed monthly rupee salary as someone who has already decided to lie to you about something.

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PART ONE

Japan needs workers. India has them. The paperwork between the two is specific, cheap to start and full of people who will charge you for it.

Japan is hiring, and Indians are barely there

Start with the size of the thing. Japan's government has set a ceiling of 805,700 Specified Skilled Worker (i) arrivals over the three years to March 2029, plus another 426,200 under a new training visa that begins in 2027. That is 1.23 million people the state has publicly committed to accepting, by field, with a number attached to each field.

The programme is not new. It started in April 2019 at zero. By the end of June 2026 the population on the SSW visa had reached 444,256 - 425,961 on SSW (i) and 18,295 on SSW (ii). SSW (ii), the version that lets you stay indefinitely, grew 130 per cent in the six months to June 2026 alone.

Now the part that matters to you. Almost none of those people are Indian.

Nationality	SSW (i) residents, end-June 2026	Share
Vietnam	176,915	39.8%
Indonesia	108,367	24.4%
Myanmar	53,441	12.0%
India	roughly 600	about 0.1%

Source: Immigration Services Agency of Japan, residence statistics for end-June 2026 (top-20 nationality table) and the Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare's 2026 survey of foreign employment, which counted 578 SSW workers of Indian nationality.

Vietnam, a country of 100 million, has 300 times India's presence on this visa. That is not because Japan prefers Vietnamese workers. It is because Vietnam built a recruitment and language-training industry around Japan fifteen years ago, and India did not.

What India's own government has promised

In August 2025 the two governments signed an Action Plan for Human Resource Exchange with a headline target of 500,000 people moving in both directions over five years, including 50,000 skilled personnel from India to Japan. The plan is specific about how: cover all SSW test categories in India, open test centres across the north, east, south, west and northeast, provide pre-departure occupational language training through Pravasi Kaushal Vikas Yojana, put Japan on the e-Migrate portal, and create an India-Japan corridor on the National Career Service platform.

In August 2026 the Commerce Minister, speaking in Osaka, said India was ready to meet Japan's request for three lakh skilled workers. That is six times the five-year target, said out loud, one year in.

Then look at what has actually moved. NSDC International, the skilling body running Japanese language training centres for this corridor, had trained about 400 candidates as of January 2026, of whom 185 were working in Japan. The Ministry of External Affairs told Parliament in March 2026 that seven Skill India International Centres were operational - Varanasi, Bhubaneswar, Hyderabad, Kanpur, Ludhiana, Bengaluru and Guwahati - and that 2,910 candidates had been trained at just two of them since 2023.

> **The honest reading of those numbers**
>
> The political will is real and the infrastructure is being built. The throughput is not there yet. That is exactly why this is a good moment to enter and a bad moment to be naive: there is a genuine, government-backed shortage of Indian candidates, surrounded by a fast-growing supply of people willing to sell you a fake one.
>
> You are early. Being early is an advantage only if you do the boring parts - the language test, the skills test, the employer contract - yourself, in the right order. That is the whole method of this book.

Why the shortage is structural, not cyclical

Japan's working-age population is shrinking while its care, logistics, construction and food industries keep running. The government's answer is imported labour with a skills test attached. The ceiling numbers are set

every five years and revised upward: the current SSW (i) cap of 805,700 is itself a reduction from the previous 820,000 for most fields, offset by the new training visa. Even after that trim, the state expects to admit more than a million foreign workers in three years.

This is a policy with a demographic engine behind it. It will not be switched off next quarter. What can change quickly is which fields are open, what the tests cost, and which nationalities the recruiters are currently favouring - which is why Chapter 3 tells you how to read the field table rather than just handing you one.

What the SSW visa actually is, and what it is not

The Specified Skilled Worker status of residence is a work visa for fourteen-to-nineteen specific industries, granted after you pass two tests. It comes in two grades, and the difference between them is the single most important thing in this chapter.

	SSW (i)	SSW (ii)
Length of stay	Up to 5 years in total (6 where there is a justified reason)	No upper limit; renewed in units of 6 months to 3 years
Family	Cannot bring spouse or children	Can bring spouse and children if requirements are met
Pay	Same as a Japanese worker doing the same job	Same as a Japanese worker doing the same job
Japanese level	A2.2 equivalent, proven by JFT-Basic or JLPT N4 or above	B1 equivalent (the ordinance takes effect 1 April 2027)
Fields open	19	11
How you get there	Skills test plus language test, or completion of Technical Intern Training (ii)	Skills test for the higher grade, from within SSW (i)

Source: Immigration Services Agency of Japan, ssw.go.jp and the agency's September 2026 system overview.

Read the family row again. On SSW (i) you cannot bring your wife or your children to Japan. For five years. That single rule changes who this visa is right for, and it is the rule that agents mention least often.

It is not a general work permit

The most common misunderstanding, and the one that costs people the most money, is that an SSW visa lets you work in Japan. It does not. It lets you work in one field, at one employer, doing a defined category of work. Your residence card carries the field. If you leave that employer you must find another job in the same field, and you must do it inside a window or you lose the status.

In practice that means the question is never "can I get to Japan". It is "can I get to Japan in a field where I can pass the skills test, and where there is a second employer I could move to if the first one turns out badly". Chapter 3 is about choosing that field. Chapter 16 is about what happens if the employer turns out badly anyway.

Two ways in, and only one of them is available to most Indians

- **The test route.** You pass a field-specific skills test and a Japanese language test from outside Japan, then find an employer who will sponsor you. This is the route for anyone reading this book, because the other route requires you to already be in Japan.
- **The Technical Intern Training route.** If you completed Technical Intern Training (ii) in the same field, the skills and language tests are waived. Very few Indians are on this path, because very few Indians have done TITP.

Where SSW sits among Japan's other visas

Visa	What it is for	Relevant to you?
Technical Intern Training (TITP)	A training programme, not a work visa. Being phased out: from 1 April 2027 it is replaced by Employment for Skill Development. Transitional rules keep existing interns going.	Only as a route to the SSW test exemption. Not a good first choice for an Indian graduate.
Employment for Skill Development (ESD)	New three-year training visa starting 1 April 2027, in 17 fields. A1 Japanese to enter, A2.1 after one year, A2.2 at the end. Then you move to SSW (i).	Yes, from 2027. It is a slower, cheaper on-ramp and it allows changing employers after one or two years. Chapter 18.

Visa	What it is for	Relevant to you?
Specified Skilled Worker (i) and (ii)	The work visa this book is about.	Yes.
Engineer / Specialist in Humanities / International Services	The white-collar visa for degree-holders doing professional work.	Only if you have a relevant degree and a professional job offer. A different book.

The 19 fields, and which ones are actually open

Japan expanded the SSW field list in January 2026, adding linen supply, logistics warehousing and resource recycling. There are now 19. But "on the list" and "open to you" are different things, and the difference is where most guides stop and this one starts.

Field	SSW (i) residents, Jun 2026	Open to new applicants?	India skills-test fee
Nursing care	79,884	Yes	Rs 1,416
Food and beverage manufacturing	100,769	Yes	Not listed for India
Industrial product manufacturing	62,033	Yes	Rs 4,700
Construction	52,132	Yes	Rs 684
Food service	49,060	NO - suspended	Rs 3,422
Agriculture	44,050	Yes	Rs 2,830
Shipbuilding and marine	11,641	Yes	Not listed for India
Building cleaning	10,171	Yes	Not listed for India
Automobile maintenance	5,235	Yes	Not listed for India
Fishery and aquaculture	4,912	Yes	Not listed for India
Aviation (ground handling)	2,803	Yes	Not listed for India
Accommodation (hotels)	2,556	Yes	Rs 4,620
Automobile transport (drivers)	558	Yes, since 2024	Not listed for India
Railway	64	Yes, since 2024	Not listed for India
Forestry and wood industry	under 100 combined	Yes, since 2024	Not listed for India
Linen supply	0	Not yet operating	None yet
Logistics warehouse	0	Not yet operating	None yet
Resource recycling	0	Not yet operating	None yet

Resident counts: Immigration Services Agency, end-June 2026 (provisional). Test fees: Prometric Japan's published India price list, gross price including tax, checked November 2026. "Not listed for India" means the test exists but Prometric's India fee table does not carry it - it may be taken in Japan or arranged through an employer, and you should confirm before assuming you can sit it from India.

The food service suspension is the trap

Food service - restaurant floor and kitchen work - is the field most Indian applicants ask about, because the work is familiar and the entry bar feels low. It has 49,060 residents and 50,000 places under the current cap. It is also, as of November 2026, closed. The Immigration Services Agency's own English page carries the line "We are not accepting new applications at this time" against the field.

If an agent offers you a food service placement today, one of two things is true: they are selling you something that does not exist, or they are counting on the suspension being lifted before you notice. Either way, ask them to show you the field status on ssw.go.jp. The conversation ends there.

How to choose a field in twenty minutes

Four filters, applied in order. Do not skip to the fourth.

1. **Can I sit the test from India?** If the skills test for a field is not offered in India, your cost and complexity go up sharply. Start with the fields that have a published India fee: nursing care, construction, agriculture, accommodation, industrial product manufacturing.

2. **Can I afford the test?** Construction is Rs 684. Industrial product manufacturing is Rs 4,700. Both are real jobs. One costs seven times less to qualify for.
3. **Does this field lead to SSW (ii)?** Only 11 of the 19 do. Industrial product manufacturing is limited to three sub-categories (machining, electrical and electronic assembly, metal surface treatment). Nursing care, construction, shipbuilding, automobile maintenance, accommodation, agriculture, fishery, food and beverage manufacturing, building cleaning, food service and railway are on the (ii) list.
4. **Can I physically do this work for five years?** Building cleaning and agriculture are outdoor and hard on the body. Nursing care involves lifting people and night shifts. Food and beverage manufacturing is cold rooms and standing. Be honest here, because a mid-contract collapse is expensive for everyone.

> **If you want the shortest possible answer**
>
> For a candidate with no Japanese, no trade certificate and a modest budget: **construction** (cheapest test, strong SSW (ii) pathway, high site demand) or **nursing care** (largest field, clearest long-term ladder, but the hardest language bar and shift work).
>
> For a candidate with an ITI or diploma in machining, electrical or welding: **industrial product manufacturing**. Higher test fee, better pay, and the three sub-categories that can reach SSW (ii).
>
> For a candidate with hotel or restaurant experience: **accommodation** now, and watch food service for the suspension lifting.

PART TWO

Two tests stand between you and the visa. One is cheap, bookable from India and failed by two out of three candidates. The other is field-specific and nobody explains it properly.

The language test, and the 33 per cent pass rate

There are two ways to prove your Japanese. The Japan Foundation Test for Basic Japanese, called JFT-Basic, is the one built for this visa. The Japanese Language Proficiency Test at N4 or above also works. Almost everyone should take the JFT-Basic, and this chapter explains why, exactly what it involves, and what the pass data says about your chances.

What the JFT-Basic actually measures

It is a computer-based test, about 50 questions, 60 minutes, in four sections: script and vocabulary, conversation and expression, listening comprehension, and reading comprehension. You answer on screen with headphones. Results are printed at the end of the session - no waiting weeks for a result letter.

The test is scored on a scale of 10 to 250. Until July 2026 it simply reported A2 or not. From August 2026 the Japan Foundation splits the result into three bands, which matters enormously because the SSW visa needs the top one.

Band	Score	What it means	Enough for SSW (i)?
A1	145 - 174	You can handle very simple, familiar exchanges.	No
A2.1	175 - 199	You have passed A1 and are on the way to A2.	No
A2.2 (A2)	200 - 250	You can hold everyday conversation and manage daily life without help.	Yes

Source: Japan Foundation press release no. 2026-016, 3 August 2026.

A2.2 is the bar. Not A2.1, not "passed the test". If your score slip says 195, you did not qualify, and you will pay the fee again.

The pass data, without the marketing

The Japan Foundation publishes implementation reports with country-level results. For the test window of 3 August to 17 September 2026, India produced the following:

Measure	India, Aug-Sep 2026
Applications	578
Candidates who actually sat the test	535
Scored A2.2 - the band the SSW visa needs	180 (33.6% of those who sat)
Scored A2.1	149 (27.9%)
Scored A1	112 (20.9%)
Below A1	about 94

Source: Japan Foundation, JFT-Basic implementation report for August-September 2026 (test sites Gurugram, Bengaluru, Guwahati).

One in three. And that is one in three of the people who were motivated enough to pay Rs 3,540 and turn up - a self-selected group that already believes it is ready. The real message is simpler: the JFT-Basic is not a formality you clear on the way to the visa. It is the actual filter, and it filters out most people.

Why 60 minutes decides this, not 60 days

The JFT-Basic is a speed test as much as a knowledge test. Fifty questions in sixty minutes across four sections, with listening that plays once. Candidates who fail usually know more Japanese than their score suggests - they lose time on reading and then guess the last eight questions.

Train with a timer from week one. Not from week ten.

The logistics: three centres, one fee, tight windows

Centre	Address	Note
Bengaluru	Prometric Testing, 3rd Floor, Tower B, Prestige ShantiNiketan, Whitefield ITPL Road	Fewest sitting days of the three
Gurgaon	Prometric Testing, 208-212 Tower A, Iris Tech Park, Sector 48, Sohna Road	Closest to Delhi NCR candidates
Guwahati	DCEL Exams India, Assam Don Bosco University, Azara campus, Airport Road	Most December-January dates; far for most applicants

The fee for India is Rs 3,000 plus tax, which comes to Rs 3,540. You pay online when you book. There is no refund and no cancellation - you can move the date, time or centre up to three business days before the test (four if it falls on a weekend or a Japanese holiday) and only if seats are free.

You do not book a single date. You book inside a window that opens at a fixed moment, and the seats go quickly because the whole country shares a handful of sitting days. The published windows for this cycle:

Test period	Booking opens
2 Oct - 15 Nov 2026	29 September 2026, about 10:00 JST (6:30 am IST)
1 Dec 2026 - 15 Jan 2027	25 November 2026, about 10:00 JST (6:30 am IST)
February - March 2027	Late January 2027 (planning date; may shift)

Source: Prometric Japan JFT-Basic test list and booking notices, checked November 2026.

Practical advice that has cost people months: set an alarm for 6:25 am IST on opening day, have a card ready, and have two backup dates chosen before you log in. Do not book "to hold a seat" - you cannot cancel, and you will be paying Rs 3,540 for a test you are not ready for.

Why not just take the JLPT?

You can. JLPT N4 or above satisfies the SSW language requirement. But three things make it the worse choice for most people.

- It runs twice a year, in July and December. Miss the registration window and you lose six months. JFT-Basic runs roughly monthly.
- Results take weeks to arrive. JFT-Basic prints your band at the end of the session, which means you can start employer conversations the same week.
- The JLPT is a general academic test. The JFT-Basic was designed around the language of daily life for a foreign worker in Japan, which is closer to what you will actually need on a factory floor or a care home.

There is one reason to prefer the JLPT: if you already hold N4 or above, you are done and should not spend money on another test. And one reason to consider it later: a JFT-Basic result is now also accepted for the Student visa at a Japanese language school, and for the new Employment for Skill Development visa from 2027 - so a single A2.2 result keeps several doors open.

The 90-day JFT-Basic plan

This is the schedule I would give a friend starting from zero. It assumes 90 to 120 minutes a day, six days a week, and a test booked for the end of week twelve. If you have less time than that, book the test later rather than compressing the plan - the fee is not refundable and the pass rate is already one in three.

What you are actually being tested on

Four sections, and they are not equally weighted in difficulty for an Indian learner.

Section	What it asks	Where Indian candidates lose marks
Script and vocabulary	Hiragana, katakana, and basic kanji in context; word meaning	Katakana speed. Loanwords are the easiest marks on the paper and most people under-practise them.
Conversation and expression	Choosing the right thing to say in a daily or workplace exchange	Politeness level. Picking the casual form in a customer situation is wrong even when the meaning is right.
Listening comprehension	Audio played once, at natural speed	Not replaying. You get one pass, and hesitation costs the next question too.
Reading comprehension	Short notices, forms, signs, simple messages	Time. Reading slowly here eats the minutes you needed for the last questions.

The twelve weeks

Weeks 1-3: the two alphabets, then stop looking at them

Hiragana and katakana in the first ten days, both, to automatic recall - not recognition. If you are still sounding out characters in week four you will not finish the reading section in the real test. Use flashcards, write them by hand, and read anything in kana out loud for ten minutes a day. Then spend the rest of the three weeks on the 300 or so words that recur in daily-life Japanese: numbers, times, dates, directions, food, transport, workplace greetings.

Weeks 4-7: Irodori A2, in order

The Japan Foundation publishes Irodori, a free Japanese course built specifically around the language a foreign resident needs for daily life and work. It is the closest published material to the JFT-Basic's actual scope, and it is free. Work through the A2 level in sequence rather than sampling it. One lesson a day, then re-read the previous day's lesson out loud before starting the new one.

This is also where you build the habit that decides the listening section: listen to the audio twice, once without the text and once with, and never read the transcript first.

Weeks 8-10: the official sample questions, timed

The JFT-Basic official site publishes sample questions. Do them under real conditions: 60 minutes, no phone, no pausing the audio. Score yourself, and record which section you lost time in, not just which answers were wrong.

Repeat the full sample set three times across these three weeks, with at least five days between attempts so you are not remembering answers. Your third attempt should be comfortably above 200 on the scale. If it is not, move the test date.

Weeks 11-12: workplace Japanese and one last mock

Shift to the vocabulary of your intended field. Every field has twenty words that will appear in your interview and your first month: safety, cleanliness, tools, shift times, instructions, apologies, asking someone to repeat. Learn those twenty words in Japanese, in sentences, out loud.

Then one final timed sample, and stop studying the day before the test. Turn up early. The centre will not let you in late.

Three habits that separate the 33 per cent from the rest

Speak out loud every day. Reading silently trains recognition; the test and the interview both need production.

Time everything from week eight. Untimed practice builds false confidence in exactly the section that fails most people.

Take the test when your third mock clears 200, not when the booking window opens. The fee is Rs 3,540 and non-refundable. Waiting one cycle costs nothing; failing costs the fee plus two months.

The skills test, field by field

The second gate is a field-specific skills test. It is set by the industry body that runs that field, not by one central authority, which is why the fees, formats and locations differ so much. It is also why you should read the official test guide for your field before you pay for anything.

What it costs from India

Field	Test	India fee (gross, incl. tax)
Construction	Construction field SSW (i) evaluation test	Rs 684
Nursing care	Long-term care SSW evaluation test (skills and Japanese)	Rs 1,416
Agriculture	Agriculture skill assessment test, level 1	Rs 2,830
Food service	Food service industry SSW (i) test	Rs 3,422 (field suspended)
Accommodation	Accommodation industry proficiency test (i)	Rs 4,620
Industrial product manufacturing	SSW (i) exam for industrial product manufacturing	Rs 4,700

Source: Prometric Japan, examination fees by country, India section, checked November 2026. Net prices before 18 per cent tax are Rs 580, 1,200, 2,399, 2,900, 3,915 and 3,983 respectively.

Look at the spread. Construction costs Rs 684 and industrial product manufacturing costs Rs 4,700 - a factor of seven for two tests of comparable seriousness. The difference is administrative, not a signal about the job. Do not read it as one.

Nursing care is two tests wearing one fee

The care field is the largest in the programme, with 79,884 residents, and it is also the most demanding to enter. The Rs 1,416 fee covers a combined skills and Japanese evaluation, and care work carries an additional language requirement that other fields do not: a care-specific Japanese evaluation, on top of the JFT-Basic or JLPT result. If you are targeting care, budget for both and plan the language work first, because the care vocabulary is the hardest part of the whole pathway.

The upside is real. Care is on the SSW (ii) list, has the second-largest cap of any field at 126,900 places, and the ladder to a long-stay career - including the separate care-worker visa for qualified staff - is the clearest of any field in the programme.

Construction is the cheapest door, and it is not a consolation prize

Construction has 52,132 SSW (i) residents and a three-year cap of 76,000 places. The skills test costs Rs 684. It leads to SSW (ii). Japanese construction firms are among the most structured employers in the programme, because the field has the longest history of accepting foreign workers and the strongest industry body behind it.

What it costs you instead is your body. Site work in Japanese summer heat, with safety equipment, is hard. If you have a trade - shuttering, bar bending, tiling, scaffolding, welding - this is the field where your existing skill converts fastest into a test pass and a decent wage.

How to prepare for a skills test

1. **Get the official test guide for your field.** Each field's testing body publishes a syllabus and sample questions, and ssw.go.jp links them from the field pages. This is the only authoritative description of what is on the paper. Everything else - coaching centres, YouTube channels, agent handouts - is a secondary interpretation of it.
2. **Check where the test is actually held.** Several fields have a published India fee, which means you can sit them here. Others do not appear on the India list at all, which usually means the test is taken in Japan, or through an employer's own arrangement. Confirm before you build a plan around it.

3. **Assume it is practical, not academic.** These tests are built to establish that you can do the job safely, so they lean on judgement questions - what to do in a specific situation, what order to do things in, what is unsafe. Experience in the trade is the best preparation.
4. **Book the language test and the skills test in parallel.** They are independent. Candidates who sequence them one after another lose three to six months for no reason.

Your honest fit test

Twelve questions. Answer them on paper, not in your head. Two points for a clear yes, one for a maybe, zero for a no.

1. Can you live without your family in the same country for five years? On SSW (i) you cannot bring a spouse or children to Japan.
2. Can you fund Rs 15,000 to Rs 40,000 of tests and documentation from your own savings, without borrowing at interest?
3. Can you study 90 minutes a day for three months, starting this week?
4. Do you have at least two years of relevant work experience, or an ITI, diploma or degree in the trade you are targeting?
5. Can you do physically demanding work for eight hours, including shifts, for five years?
6. Can you follow written safety rules in a language you are still learning, and ask for help when you do not understand?
7. Are you willing to live in a small town or rural area, not Tokyo?
8. Do you have a clean passport and no adverse immigration history anywhere?
9. Can you say no to an agent who is pressuring you, even if it costs you the placement?
10. Do you have someone - family, a friend, a bank - who can support you for two months if the first job falls through?
11. Are you going for a career and an income, rather than to escape a situation?
12. Have you read the actual employment contract terms - hours, overtime, deductions, housing cost - and not just the salary headline?

Scoring

Score	What it means
20-24	Go. Start with the language test this month and read Chapter 8 before you speak to a single agent.
15-19	Go, but fix the gaps first. A "no" on question 1 or question 11 is a reason to pause, not to adjust the arithmetic.
10-14	Wait one cycle. Do the language work, save the test money, and re-take this in three months. The corridor will still be open.
Below 10	This is the wrong visa for you right now. Chapter 18 describes the 2027 training route, which is slower, cheaper and allows changing employers - it may fit your situation better.

Three people who should not read further

The visa is designed for semi-skilled work. It is a good deal for a welder from Ludhiana with eight years on site and no degree. It is a bad deal for three specific types of reader.

- **The graduate who wants a white-collar career.** If you have a B.Tech and want to write software in Tokyo, the SSW visa is not the door. The Engineer / Specialist in Humanities visa is, and it needs a relevant degree and a professional job offer. Taking SSW to "get into Japan and then switch" does not work - the status is field-bound and changing it requires a new qualification.
- **The person in a hurry.** From today, a realistic timeline to landing in Japan is nine to eighteen months: three months of language, the test cycle, the skills test, employer search, certificate of eligibility, visa. Anyone offering you Japan in six weeks is selling something else.
- **The person who cannot say no to an agent.** The single strongest predictor of a bad outcome in this corridor is not Japanese ability. It is whether you can walk away from a bad offer. Chapter 11 exists for you, and if you only read one chapter, read that one.

PART THREE

A real employer, a contract you can read, and a certificate of eligibility with your name on it. In that order, and never the other way round.

Seven legitimate ways to find a real employer

The first thing to understand is that the SSW system does not require an agent. India's own embassy in Tokyo says so in writing: in India's system, the use of a sending organisation is optional, and a Japanese employer may either conclude a contract with a candidate referred by an Indian sending organisation or conclude it directly with the candidate. That single fact removes the main justification for the five-lakh-rupee "package".

So the search is a search, not a purchase. These are the channels that exist, roughly in order of how much control they give you.

1. Apply directly to Japanese employers

Japanese companies hiring under SSW post vacancies on their own sites, on Japanese job boards, and through their industry associations. Applying directly is slower and requires you to write in Japanese or English, but it is free, and it puts the employment contract in front of you without a middleman's markup. This is how the majority of Vietnamese and Indonesian workers arrive, and there is no rule against an Indian doing the same.

2. Registered Support Organisations

Every SSW (i) worker must receive ten defined forms of support - explained in Chapter 15 - either from the employer or from a Registered Support Organisation acting on the employer's behalf. These organisations are registered with the Immigration Services Agency and appear on its published list. They are not recruitment agents, but the good ones know which employers are hiring, and dealing with a registered entity is verifiable in a way that a WhatsApp number is not.

3. The government skilling channel

NSDC International runs Japanese Language Training Centres and works with employers in care and hospitality. Seven Skill India International Centres were operational as of March 2026: Varanasi, Bhubaneswar, Hyderabad, Kanpur, Ludhiana, Bengaluru and Guwahati, with Jaipur added in May 2026. These are genuine and government-backed.

Two caveats, stated plainly. First, the training fee and boarding are usually borne by the candidate, so "free government programme" is not accurate. Second, throughput is small - roughly 400 candidates trained across the whole corridor by early 2026 - so treat it as one channel among several, not a guaranteed seat.

4. Hello Work and the foreign-worker service centres

Hello Work is Japan's public employment service, free to use, with consultation counters for foreign residents and specialised foreign employment service centres in the larger cities. It is most useful once you are in Japan and looking to change employer within your field, but it is also a legitimate place to ask what is currently being advertised.

5. Field industry bodies

Several fields run their own matching and testing infrastructure. Construction is the most developed, because it has the longest history of accepting foreign workers. These bodies publish test guides, run the tests, and in some cases operate job-matching for member employers. Start from the field pages on ssw.go.jp and follow the link to the field's own organisation.

6. Approved sending organisations, for verification

The Organisation for Technical Intern Training publishes a list of approved sending organisations by country, including India. It exists for the training programme rather than SSW directly, but it is a useful cross-check: if someone claims to be an approved sending organisation for India and is not on that list, you have your answer.

7. Registered Recruiting Agents, used properly

A Recruiting Agent registered with India's Ministry of External Affairs is a lawful way to be placed abroad, and the registration exists to protect you. Chapter 11 explains exactly what such an agent may charge, how to

verify one in two minutes, and what to do when they overstep. If you use this channel, use it with the receipt in your hand.

> **The test that separates a channel from a con**
>
> A legitimate channel can tell you, in writing and before you pay anything, the name of the Japanese company, its address, the field of work, the monthly wage, the working hours, and the name of the person who will sign your contract.
>
> If any of those five items is missing at the point money is requested, you are not looking at a channel. You are looking at a sales funnel.

The CV and the interview

Japanese hiring for this visa screens for four things, in this order: reliability, safety awareness, willingness to learn the language, and physical capability. Your CV and your interview should be built to answer those four, not to list your achievements.

The document Japanese employers expect

Japan has a standard resume format, the rirekisho, and employers expect it. It is a two-page form: personal details with a photograph, education and employment history in chronological order with no gaps unexplained, qualifications and licences, a short statement of what you want to do, and a request section. Download a current template rather than inventing a layout - a CV in an unfamiliar format reads as carelessness here.

Three rules that matter more than the layout.

- **Explain every gap.** A year with nothing on it is a question the interviewer will ask and you will answer badly under pressure. Put the reason in the document: family responsibility, study, seasonal work.
- **Name your licences exactly.** ITI trade, driving licence, welding certificate, caregiving certificate - with the issuing body and the year. These convert directly into skills-test confidence and, sometimes, into a higher starting wage.
- **Write the reason for applying in one honest paragraph.** "I want to earn and learn" is fine. "I want to experience Japanese culture" is what every rejected application says.

The interview, decoded

Expect a first round by video, in Japanese if your level allows and in English otherwise, followed by an in-person round in India organised by the employer or the sending organisation. The questions are predictable, and they are not testing your personality. They are testing whether you will still be there in year three.

Question	What they are actually checking	How to answer
Tell me about yourself.	Whether you can speak clearly and briefly.	Ninety seconds. Where you are from, what you do, how long you have done it, why Japan. Stop talking at ninety seconds.
Why Japan, and not another country?	Whether you have a real reason or a generic one.	Name the field and the skill you want. "Construction pays more in the Gulf but I want to learn Japanese construction safety standards" is a real answer.
What work have you done?	Whether your experience is real.	Specifics: tools, materials, team size, what you were responsible for. Numbers beat adjectives.
Can you work night shifts and overtime?	Whether you will refuse in month two.	Answer honestly. If you cannot, say so now - a mid-contract refusal is worse for you than not being selected.
How is your Japanese?	Whether you will actually keep studying.	State your band and your study plan. "A2.2, and I am continuing with Irodori B1" is better than "a little".
What will you do if you do not understand an instruction?	Safety awareness. This is the most important question in the interview.	"I stop, I ask again, and I do not guess." Say it exactly like that. In Japanese: wakarimasen, mou ichido onegaishimasu.
How long do you plan to stay?	Retention.	Five years, with the intention of moving to SSW (ii) if I qualify. That is the answer they want and it happens to be the truth for most people.

Two things to bring to every interview

Your JFT-Basic or JLPT result slip, and a one-page list of your trade experience with dates. Both are documents the interviewer can point at, and documents end arguments about whether you are ready.

The offer, the contract, and the certificate of eligibility

The sequence is fixed and it is worth memorising, because every fake placement gets it wrong somewhere. A real SSW process runs in this order.

1. **Employment contract signed with the Japanese employer.** Signed by the employer and by you. Not by an agent on your behalf.
2. **Explanation of the contract, before you apply.** Your employer is required to explain the contract and the job to you in detail before you submit your residence application. This is one of the ten mandatory support items. If nobody has explained your contract to you, the process has already broken.
3. **Certificate of Eligibility application, filed in Japan by the employer.** The employer applies to the local immigration bureau. This is the step where the employer's bona fides are checked - whether they have the systems, the support arrangements and the pay parity required.
4. **COE issued, and the original sent to you in India.** The certificate is a piece of paper with your details on it. It is not a visa.
5. **Visa application at the Embassy of Japan in India, through VFS.** You submit the COE original with the visa application. The visa fee for Indian nationals is Rs 500 for a single or multiple entry visa, from 1 July 2026, plus the VFS service fee.
6. **Landing.** At the port of entry, immigration checks that you meet the landing conditions and grants the Specified Skilled Worker status. Your residence card is issued.

> **Two documents that are not the same document**
>
> **The COE is not a visa.** Holding a certificate of eligibility does not mean you may enter Japan. It means immigration has already examined the application and found it meets the criteria, which makes the visa step faster - not automatic.
>
> **A visa is not a job.** If your employment ends, the visa does not protect the job, and the job does not automatically protect the visa. That is why Chapter 16 matters.

What to check in the contract, line by line

Clause	What good looks like	What should worry you
Monthly wage	A figure at or above the local minimum wage for your prefecture, and equal to what a Japanese worker in the same job gets	A wage quoted only in rupees, or only as "after deductions"
Working hours	Stated scheduled hours per month, plus a stated overtime arrangement and overtime rate	"As required", or no hours stated at all
Deductions	Itemised: social insurance, tax, rent, utilities. Each with an amount	A single "management charge" or "service fee" line
Housing	Whether the employer provides housing, guarantees a lease, or deducts rent - and how much	Rent deducted with no stated amount
Insurance	Enrolment in health insurance and pension as required by law	Any suggestion that you will be paid in cash and not enrolled
Probation	A stated period and the same or better conditions during it	A long probation at a lower wage
Termination	The notice required on both sides	Penalties for leaving, or a "bond" you must repay
Support	Named as employer-provided or via a named Registered Support Organisation	No mention of support at all

If the contract is in Japanese and you cannot read it, have it translated before signing - and pay a translator, not the agent who brought you the contract. An agent who offers to explain the contract he is being paid to deliver is not a neutral translator.

PART FOUR

What an agent may legally charge, what the state will actually deduct, and how to keep both sets of numbers straight.

The scam wall: what an agent may legally charge you

This is the most valuable chapter in the book, and the shortest way to use it is this: print the table below, keep it on your phone, and read it before any conversation about money.

The legal ceiling, in numbers

Item	What the rules say	What you should pay
Recruiting agent service charge (India)	Under the Emigration Act 1983 and the rules made under it, a registered recruiting agent may not collect more than Rs 30,000 plus 18 per cent GST, and must issue a receipt.	Maximum Rs 35,400 all-in, with a receipt
Anything billed as a separate "package" item	The cap covers the agent's own costs of recruiting you - sourcing, advertising, trade tests, attestation, interview travel, the bank guarantee they must lodge, and their office overhead.	Nothing extra. It is inside the cap.
Visa fee (Japan, Indian national)	Rs 500 for a single or multiple entry visa, from 1 July 2026, plus the VFS service fee. The Embassy states that the visa fee and the service charge are the only amounts you pay for a visa.	Rs 500 plus the VFS fee, paid to VFS
JFT-Basic test	Prometric's published India price.	Rs 3,540
Skills test	Prometric's published India price for your field.	Rs 684 to Rs 4,700 depending on field
Placement fee to a Japanese employer or its agent	Japanese employment law restricts charging the worker for job placement.	Nothing. Ask for it in writing if they insist.
"Security deposit" or "bond"	Deposits and penalty contracts are prohibited in Japan's training programme, and a bond you repay for leaving is a penalty by another name.	Nothing
Your own real costs	Language classes, medicals, passport, flights.	Paid to the actual provider, itemised, never bundled

Sources: Ministry of External Affairs advisory on overcharging by agents for overseas recruitment; MEA guidance on complaints against recruiting agents; Embassy of Japan in India visa page; Prometric Japan fee tables. Checked November 2026.

The gap between Rs 35,400 and the Rs 2 lakh to Rs 8 lakh that agents are reported to be collecting is not a negotiation. It is the fraud.

The three packages, and how each one works

The bundle

A single all-inclusive figure covering "training, documentation, medical, visa, ticket and placement", with half payable now. Bundling is the technique: nothing is itemised, so nothing can be price-checked, and every component sounds plausible. The defence is mechanical - ask for an itemised quote with each line priced, and compare each line against the table above. A legitimate operator can produce that quote in ten minutes, because their costs are real.

The guaranteed visa

"Direct selection, no interview, no Japanese needed, visa guaranteed." Every element of that sentence is impossible. The visa decision belongs to Japanese immigration. The language requirement is set by ordinance. The skills test is set by the field's industry body. Nobody can guarantee an outcome that three separate institutions control.

The deposit

A refundable security deposit, returned after two years. Or a bond repaying training costs if you leave early. This one can cost you the visa as well as the money, because a worker who is contractually trapped with one employer cannot exercise the job-change rights the visa actually gives them - and immigration takes a dim view of arrangements that remove them.

What the fraud actually looks like in India

This is not hypothetical. In June 2026 the Delhi Police arrested two men from Bareilly in a case where a woman had been cheated of Rs 1.63 lakh on the promise of a job in Japan; the syndicate posed as recruitment consultants, ran fake interviews, and collected money under the headings of embassy clearance, visa processing and ministry attestation. In August 2026, reporting from Karimnagar described agents across northern Telangana collecting Rs 3 lakh to Rs 8 lakh in advance for overseas jobs including Japan, through WhatsApp, Telegram and YouTube.

The Ministry of External Affairs has issued a standing advisory: unregistered agents are charging Rs 2 lakh to Rs 5 lakh, operating through Facebook, WhatsApp and text messages, providing little or no verifiable location, and communicating only through WhatsApp to make themselves hard to identify.

Six checks, two minutes each

1. **Check the agent's registration.** Every registered Recruiting Agent holds a licence number, which must be displayed in their office and in their advertising. Look it up on emigrate.gov.in under "List of active RA". If the number is not there, stop.
2. **Check the employer, separately.** Ask for the Japanese company's full legal name and address, then find the company's own website and contact it through the address on that site - not through any link the agent gives you. Ask whether they are recruiting for that field.
3. **Check the field status.** Open ssw.go.jp and confirm the field is open to new applications. Food service is currently closed, and a placement offer in a closed field is proof of the problem.
4. **Check the money against the table.** Anything above Rs 35,400 to a registered agent, or any demand for a deposit, is outside the rules.
5. **Check the payment route.** Money goes to a company account with a receipt. Never to a personal UPI handle, never in cash, never without a receipt. A receipt is a legal requirement, and the agent has lodged a Rs 50 lakh bank guarantee with the government precisely so that a receipt means something.
6. **Check the pressure.** "Two seats left, pay today" is not how a government programme or a Japanese employer operates. It is how a sales funnel operates.

The insurance nobody tells you about

Registered recruiting agents are required to buy Pravasi Bharatiya Bima Yojana cover for workers they send abroad. The premium is Rs 275 for two years or Rs 375 for three years, and the cover includes a Rs 10 lakh sum assured on death and on work-related injury, plus medical expenses. It is cheap, it is mandatory, and its absence tells you something about the agent. Ask for the policy.

If you have already paid

You are not without recourse, and the amount is recoverable in more cases than people expect, because the registered agent has a bank guarantee behind them.

- Lodge a complaint with the office of the Protector General of Emigrants, with the agent's details and your receipts.
- Register a grievance on the MADAD portal, or contact the Overseas Workers Resource Centre for guidance.
- For fraud - fake offers, fake interviews, money taken for services that do not exist - file a police complaint. The Delhi case above was registered under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and produced arrests, because the money trail through bank accounts is traceable.
- Inform the Indian embassy or consulate if you are already abroad, and keep every receipt, screenshot and chat log. The money trail is the case.

Gross to net: what lands in your bank account

Every salary figure you will be shown - by an agent, by a job posting, by a friend already in Japan - is a gross figure before Japanese deductions. The deductions are substantial and entirely normal, and not knowing them is how people arrive expecting one number and receive another.

The wage you can actually expect

Two official statistics answer this, and they measure different things. Read the labels carefully, because they differ by about 30,000 yen a month.

Measure	Figure	What it includes
Monthly contractual cash earnings, SSW workers	JPY 254,100	Scheduled pay including regular allowances. From MHLW's 2026 survey of foreign employment, which also recorded 163.1 scheduled hours and 20.3 hours of overtime a month.
Scheduled pay excluding overtime and bonus, SSW workers	JPY 221,400	Base scheduled pay only. From MHLW's 2025 wage structure survey. Average age 29.5, average tenure 2.4 years.
Actual entry-level offer, hospitality, Indian recruitment drive	JPY 183,000 - 190,000	Gross monthly for restaurant service and kitchen staff, as published in a government channel's own job notice.

Sources: MHLW, 2026 Survey of Foreign Employment Status; MHLW, 2025 Basic Survey on Wage Structure, table 9; state government publication of an NSDC International hospitality placement notice.

The honest range for a first SSW job is JPY 180,000 to 260,000 a month gross, depending on field, prefecture and overtime. Fields with low domestic wages - care, food manufacturing, accommodation - sit at the bottom of that range. Construction, shipbuilding and industrial manufacturing sit higher.

The floor: minimum wage

Japan's prefectural minimum wages were revised for fiscal 2026, with a national weighted average of JPY 1,177 per hour, up JPY 56 - the second largest increase since the system began in 1978. The new rates took effect between 1 October and 2 December 2026.

Prefecture	Minimum wage, FY2026 (JPY/hour)
Tokyo	1,280
Kanagawa	1,279
Osaka	1,231
Saitama	1,196
Aichi	1,195
Chiba	1,195
National weighted average	1,177
Miyazaki (lowest)	1,085

Source: MHLW, FY2026 regional minimum wage decisions, September 2026.

At the national average and 163.1 scheduled hours, the floor is about JPY 192,000 a month before overtime. That is the number below which a contract is unlawful, not the number you should aim for.

The deductions

Deduction	2026 rate	Your share
Health insurance	9.90% national average; 9.85% in Tokyo; varies by prefecture from 9.21% to 10.55%	Half

Deduction	2026 rate	Your share
Long-term care insurance	1.62%, only if you are aged 40 to 64	Half
Child and childcare support levy	0.23%, new from April 2026	Half
Employees' pension	18.3%	Half (9.15%)
Employment insurance	1.35% total in general business; 0.5% is yours	0.5% (0.6% in construction, agriculture, forestry, fishery)
Income tax	Progressive, 5% to 45%, multiplied by 1.021	All of it
Resident tax	About 10% of prior-year taxable income, plus a flat per-capita levy	All of it, from your second year

Sources: MHLW social insurance premium page and 2026 rate tables; Japan Health Insurance Association prefectural rates for fiscal 2026.

A worked month, at JPY 254,100

Take a 29-year-old worker in Osaka on the average SSW wage, single, no dependants, in their second year or later - so resident tax applies.

Line	Calculation	Yen
Gross monthly pay	Given	254,100
Standard monthly remuneration	The pay grade the premiums are charged on	260,000
Health insurance	260,000 x 10.13% / 2	13,169
Child support levy	260,000 x 0.23% / 2	299
Employees' pension	260,000 x 18.3% / 2	23,790
Employment insurance	254,100 x 0.5%	1,271
Income tax	Withholding on the monthly table	about 6,700
Resident tax	Prior year's income x 10%, divided by 12	about 13,700
Net pay	Gross minus the lines above	**about 195,200**

Illustrative calculation using published 2026 rates. Resident tax is based on the previous year's income and is nil in your first year in Japan. Your actual figures depend on your prefecture, your pay grade and your dependants. Treat this as an order of magnitude, not a payslip.

The two numbers worth remembering: in your first year, expect roughly 82 per cent of gross in your bank account. From the second year, when resident tax starts, expect roughly 77 per cent. If anyone quotes you a net figure above 85 per cent of gross on a standard contract, they have either forgotten resident tax or are not enrolling you in insurance - and both of those are problems you will discover in Japan, not in India.

What you can actually save, and how to send it home

Take the net figure from the last chapter - about JPY 195,000 a month on an average SSW wage - and subtract what living costs. Two things make this easier in Japan than in most destination countries, and one thing makes it harder.

Housing is often handled for you

Helping you prepare housing and sign contracts for electricity and gas is one of the ten support obligations on your employer. In practice that means one of three arrangements: company-owned housing with rent deducted from pay, a lease the company guarantees with rent you pay directly, or a referral with no guarantee at all. The first two are common and are why SSW workers can save on a wage that looks modest by Japanese standards.

Ask which arrangement applies before you sign, and get the rent figure in the contract. A rent deduction with no stated amount is the single most common way a good-looking wage turns into a poor one.

The saving arithmetic, in yen only

Scenario	Net pay	Living cost	Saved per month	Saved in 5 years
Frugal, company housing, cooking at home	195,000	80,000	115,000	6,900,000
Moderate, shared housing	195,000	110,000	85,000	5,100,000
Comfortable, own apartment, eating out	195,000	150,000	45,000	2,700,000

Those are gross savings over sixty months, before flights home, before anything you send to family, and before the cost of returning. They are also the reason this visa is worth the two tests: at the middle scenario, five years of work produces a sum that is difficult to accumulate in semi-skilled employment almost anywhere else, and you finish it with a trade qualification, a language, and an option to stay.

> **Why this book will not convert yen to rupees for you**
>
> The yen-rupee rate has moved by more than a fifth within a single recent year. A conversion printed in a book is wrong by the time it is read, and a conversion printed by an agent is usually wrong in the agent's favour.
>
> Do this instead: work out your monthly saving in yen, then multiply by the rate on the day you actually remit. If you want a planning figure, use a rate deliberately lower than today's, so your plan survives a bad year.

Sending money home

- **Open a Japanese bank account in your first week.** Your employer or support organisation is obliged to help you set one up. Japan Post Bank and the large commercial banks all offer remittance services to India.
- **Compare the total cost, not the headline fee.** The rate spread is usually a larger cost than the transfer fee. Send a test amount first and check what actually arrives.
- **Keep every remittance record.** Purpose codes, receipts and bank statements matter when you are asked, later, to explain funds.
- **Do not use an agent's remittance service.** There is no reason for your salary to pass through a third party, and every reason for it not to.

Tax: the part most people get wrong

You will pay Japanese income tax and, from your second year, Japanese resident tax. Whether you also owe tax in India depends on your residence status there, which depends on how many days you spend in India in a financial year - not on how you feel about it.

India and Japan have a tax treaty that allocates taxing rights between the two countries and provides relief against double taxation, so the same income is not taxed twice in the ordinary case. The practical requirements

are unglamorous and easy: keep your Japanese withholding statement (the gensen choshuhyo your employer issues each year), keep your payslips, and keep your remittance records. Then have a chartered accountant look at your position in your first year abroad rather than your fourth.

This is general information, not tax advice, and the amounts involved are large enough that a two-thousand-rupee consultation is the best-value purchase in this entire process.

PART FIVE

The document sequence, the first thirty days, and the rules that catch people out in month six.

Documents and the real timeline

Here is the whole process on one page, with the waits in the right places. The waits are the part nobody warns you about, and they are why "Japan in two months" is a lie told by people who have never done it.

Stage	Who does it	Realistic duration
Japanese study to A2.2	You	3 months at 90 minutes a day, if starting from zero
Book and sit the JFT-Basic	You, at a Prometric centre	Booking window to result: 3 to 8 weeks
Book and sit the skills test for your field	You	1 to 3 months, depending on the field's test calendar
Employer search, interviews, contract	You and the employer	2 to 5 months. This is the longest and least predictable stage.
Certificate of Eligibility application and decision	The employer, in Japan	Typically 1 to 3 months. Standard processing, not a promise.
Visa application at the Embassy of Japan, via VFS	You	Processing times vary significantly with application volume and cannot be expedited
Departure and landing	You	Days

Durations are ranges from the published process and reported experience, not guarantees. The certificate of eligibility stage is decided by immigration and the visa stage by the embassy; neither can be accelerated by paying anyone.

The document set

Assemble this before you speak to an employer, because a candidate with a complete file gets taken seriously and a candidate without one gets stalled.

- Passport valid for at least the length of your intended stay, with blank pages
- JFT-Basic result slip or JLPT certificate at N4 or above
- Skills test pass certificate for your field
- Signed employment contract, in Japanese with a translation you commissioned
- Certificate of Eligibility original, once issued
- Visa application form, photograph to the specified size, submitted through VFS
- Rirekisho in the Japanese format, with photograph
- Educational certificates and mark sheets
- Experience letters from each employer, on letterhead, stating your role, dates and duties
- Trade licences or ITI certificates, with the issuing body named
- Police clearance certificate, if the employer or embassy asks for one
- Medical certificate, if the employer requires it

Three document mistakes that cost months

A name that does not match. Your passport, your test result slip and your contract must carry your name identically. A missing middle name on one document is a re-application, not a conversation.

An experience letter that says nothing. "Worked as a technician" is not evidence of a trade. It must name the role, the dates and the duties, and it must be signed by someone whose designation is stated.

Paying a translator through the agent. Use your own translator and keep the invoice. If the contract turns out to be different from what you were told, you will want a record of who translated it.

Landing: your first thirty days

Your employer owes you ten specific forms of support under the SSW rules, and the first thirty days are when most of them are supposed to happen. Knowing the list is how you tell the difference between an employer who is organised and one who is not.

The ten obligations, in the agency's own words

1. Explaining your contract and your job to you in detail, before you apply for the status of residence.
2. Meeting you at the airport when you arrive, and accompanying you to the security check when you leave Japan.
3. Helping you prepare housing and sign contracts for electricity and gas, including acting as guarantor or providing company housing, and helping you open a bank account and set up a phone.
4. Giving you an orientation on living in Japan - rules and etiquette, how to use buses and trains, what to do in an earthquake.
5. Accompanying you to city hall and other offices for procedures, and helping you fill in the paperwork.
6. Helping you find a school to study Japanese.
7. Holding meetings to solve your problems and complaints, with advice in your native language.
8. Helping you communicate with Japanese people in your area.
9. Helping you find your next job if the employer intends to lay you off.
10. Holding a meeting with you at least once every three months.

If you are not receiving these, the Immigration Services Agency's own guidance is to contact the nearest immigration office. That is a real remedy and it is not a career-ending move.

The first week, in order

1. **Get your residence card.** It is issued at the airport on arrival at the major ports of entry. Carry it with you at all times - this is a legal obligation, not advice, and being stopped without it is an offence.
2. **Register your address at the city hall** where you live, within the deadline your municipality sets - fourteen days is the standard. Take your passport and residence card. Your employer or support organisation is obliged to accompany you.
3. **Get your health insurance card.** Enrolment in Japanese health insurance is compulsory. Once enrolled you pay 30 per cent of most medical costs, which makes a doctor's visit inexpensive rather than frightening.
4. **Open a bank account.** You will need your residence card and, at some banks, proof of address. Your employer helps; that is obligation three.
5. **Get a phone number.** A Japanese number is required for almost every administrative step that follows.
6. **Apply for your My Number card** after address registration. It becomes your identifier for tax and social security.

The first month, in order

- Learn the route to work and the route to the nearest hospital, on foot, before you need either.
- Learn the garbage separation rules for your ward. They are specific, they are enforced socially, and getting them wrong is the fastest way to annoy neighbours.
- Find out where your ward office's consultation counter for foreign residents is, and what languages it covers.
- Photograph your payslip and your contract, and send the photographs to someone you trust in India. If anything goes wrong later, that copy exists outside Japan.
- Register for the Japanese language course your employer is obliged to help you find. The single strongest protection against a bad employer is being able to understand what is being said about you.

The rules that trip people up in month six

Most of the failures in this programme are not dramatic. They are a worker who took a second job without permission, or left a bad employer without telling immigration, or let a support meeting slide because the shifts were long. Each of those is avoidable in five minutes.

Your status is tied to a field, not to a company

You may change employers within your field. You may not change fields without qualifying in the new one. Any work outside your status - a weekend job in a restaurant, helping a friend's business, driving for a delivery app - requires permission you almost certainly do not have.

When your employer changes, you must notify immigration. Confirm the exact deadline and form with your support organisation rather than relying on memory, because the notification obligation is strict and administrative lapses are treated as such even when nothing dishonest happened.

If the job goes wrong

1. **Do not simply stop going.** Absence without process is what turns a bad job into a status problem.
2. **Tell your support organisation in writing.** They have obligations, and a written record starts them.
3. **Look for a new employer in the same field immediately.** Your employer is obliged to help you find one if they intend to lay you off. Use that.
4. **Use the free consultation services.** Japan's labour standards offices and the foreign worker consultation services exist for exactly this, cost nothing, and are used by Japanese workers too.
5. **Keep paying your obligations.** Health insurance and pension enrolment continue to matter, and gaps create problems at renewal.

Your labour rights, in plain terms

- The prefectural minimum wage applies to you. It is not negotiable downward and it is not reduced because you are a foreign worker.
- Overtime is paid at a premium - at least 25 per cent above the normal rate for ordinary overtime, with higher premiums for late-night and holiday work.
- Your pay must be at least equal to what a Japanese worker doing the same job receives. This is a condition of the employer's acceptance, not a courtesy.
- Wages are paid into a bank account in your name, with a payslip showing the deductions.
- You have the right to consult a labour standards inspection office without your employer's permission or knowledge.

The practical rules nobody puts in a brochure

- **Carry your residence card.** Always.
- **Driving.** An Indian licence is not directly usable. Conversion is possible at your prefectural licence centre but involves document checks and, in most cases, a written and practical test. Do not drive on an unconverted licence, and do not believe anyone who says you can.
- **Earthquakes.** Your orientation covers this; take it seriously. Know your ward's evacuation point and keep your documents in one bag you can grab.
- **Alcohol and public behaviour.** Drinking in public is legal and driving after any alcohol is not. The penalties are severe and apply to foreign residents identically.
- **Quiet hours and separation.** Japanese residential life runs on rules about noise, bins and shared spaces that are stricter than you expect. Follow them and you will be left alone; ignore them and you will not.

PART SIX

Five years is not the end of the story, if you choose a field that has a second rung - and if you clear a language bar that is about to get higher.

SSW (i) to SSW (ii): the rung that changes everything

SSW (i) is a five-year visa with no family and a hard end. SSW (ii) has no upper limit on length of stay and allows your spouse and children to join you. It is the difference between a five-year work stint and a life.

It is also being used. SSW (ii) residents went from 7,955 at the end of 2025 to 18,295 at the end of June 2026 - a 130 per cent increase in six months. That is the fastest growth of any category in the programme, and it tells you that employers are now actively promoting workers into it rather than treating it as theoretical.

The three conditions

1. **Be in a field that has a (ii) grade.** Only 11 of the 19 fields do. Nursing care, building cleaning, industrial product manufacturing (three sub-categories only), construction, shipbuilding, automobile maintenance, accommodation, agriculture, fishery, food and beverage manufacturing, food service and railway are on the list. Aviation and automobile transport are not.
2. **Pass the skills test for the higher grade.** This is a real examination of advanced skill in your trade, and it is where most candidates who try, fail. Prepare for it from year three, not year five.
3. **Clear the higher Japanese requirement.** SSW (ii) currently requires B1 equivalent, and the ordinance setting that level takes effect on 1 April 2027. If you are planning this route, your language study does not stop at A2.2 - it restarts.

> **Choose your field as if you were choosing your thirties**
>
> The field decision in Chapter 3 is not a two-year decision. It determines whether you have a second rung at all. Two candidates with identical Japanese and identical budgets can end up in completely different places at year six, purely because one chose a field with a (ii) grade and the other chose one without.
>
> If indefinite stay and family reunification matter to you - and for most people considering five years abroad, they do - then filter the field list by the (ii) column first, before pay, before test fee, before anything.

After SSW (ii)

SSW (ii) can be renewed without limit and allows dependants, which is what makes the ordinary permanent residence criteria reachable: a period of continuous residence, good conduct, and sufficient means of livelihood. It is not automatic and it is not fast, but it is a path that exists, and it does not exist from SSW (i).

The honest summary: SSW (i) is a well-paid five-year contract. SSW (ii) is immigration. Treat the field choice accordingly.

The 2027 training route, and who should use it

On 1 April 2027 Japan replaces its Technical Intern Training programme with a new status of residence called Employment for Skill Development, or ESD. The law was passed in June 2024, the operational guidelines were published in February 2026, and the system opens for arrivals from April 2027. If your timeline stretches into 2027 - and most readers' will - you need to know how it works, because for some of you it is the better door.

What it is

	Employment for Skill Development (ESD)	SSW (i)
Purpose	Train you to SSW (i) level over three years through work	Employ you as a ready worker
Length	Three years in total	Up to five years
Fields	17 (excludes aviation and automobile transport)	19
Japanese on entry	A1 equivalent. Care requires A2.2; railway A1.	A2.2 equivalent
Japanese after one year	A2.1 equivalent	Not applicable
Japanese at the end	A2.2 equivalent	Not applicable
Changing employer	Allowed on your own initiative after one or two years, depending on the field, subject to conditions	Allowed within the field, with notification
What you need to enter	No skills test at entry	Skills test plus language test
What you need to leave	Pass the skills and language tests to move to SSW (i) - it is not automatic	Nothing
Acceptance ceiling	426,200 places through March 2029	805,700 places through March 2029

Sources: Immigration Services Agency, outline of the Employment for Skill Development system (revised July 2026) and the system overview dated September 2026; Japan Foundation press release 2026-016.

Why it might be right for you

- **The language bar is A1, not A2.2.** If you have tried the JFT-Basic and landed at A2.1, ESD is a route you can enter now rather than after another three months of study.
- **No skills test to get in.** You learn the trade in Japan rather than proving it before you arrive.
- **You can change employer.** After one or two years, depending on field, you may move on your own initiative. That is a genuine protection, and it is the change that the old training programme most needed.

Why it might not be

- **Three years at trainee conditions.** You are a trainee on a training visa, not a worker on a work visa, and the pay and progression reflect that.
- **It does not lead anywhere automatically.** At the end you must pass the SSW (i) tests. Candidates who fail do not simply convert.
- **It is a longer path to the same place.** If you can clear A2.2 now, going straight to SSW (i) saves you three years of trainee wages and puts you on the (ii) ladder sooner.

> **The decision, in one line**
>
> If you can pass the JFT-Basic at A2.2 within six months, go direct to SSW (i). If you cannot, or if you have no trade experience to be tested on, ESD from April 2027 is the honest on-ramp - and it is better than paying an agent five lakh rupees to pretend otherwise.

PART SEVEN

Six fields, honestly described: who fits, what the work is, what it pays, where it leads, and the part that will be hardest.

Nursing care: the biggest field and the hardest language bar

Field snapshot	Detail
Residents, June 2026	79,884 - the second largest field
Three-year acceptance cap	126,900 places
India skills-test fee	Rs 1,416 for the combined skills and Japanese evaluation
Reaches SSW (ii)?	Yes
Japanese requirement	A2.2 plus a care-specific Japanese evaluation

The work. Assisting elderly and disabled people with the tasks of daily living: bathing, meals, toileting, mobility, repositioning, recreation, and recording. It is physical, it is intimate, and it is supervised by qualified care staff. It is not cleaning and it is not nursing - it is the human assistance layer between the two.

Who it suits. People who are patient, physically capable of lifting and supporting another adult, comfortable with bodies and dignity, and willing to do shift work including nights. Experience in a hospital, nursing home, or caring for a family member is directly relevant and should be in your experience letters.

Why it is worth considering anyway. It has the clearest ladder in the entire programme. Care is on the SSW (ii) list, the acceptance cap is the largest of any single field after industrial manufacturing, and Japan has a separate care-worker visa route for people who go on to qualify as care workers. Of all nineteen fields, this is the one where a five-year decision most often becomes a twenty-year career.

The hard part. The language. Care carries an additional Japanese evaluation on top of the JFT-Basic, and the vocabulary is specialised: medical terms, body parts, polite forms for speaking to residents, and the indirect language Japanese care settings use for sensitive tasks. Indian workers are a very small presence in this field - 336 on SSW (i) in care as of June 2025 - and the language is the main reason.

If you choose it. Start the language six months before anything else, budget for the care-specific evaluation as well as the JFT-Basic, and target employers with an established foreign-staff training programme. Ask in the interview how many foreign staff they currently employ and how long they have stayed. The answer predicts your experience better than the wage does.

Food and beverage manufacturing: the largest field of all

Field snapshot	Detail
Residents, June 2026	100,769 - the largest field
Three-year acceptance cap	133,500 places
India skills-test fee	Not on Prometric's published India list; confirm before planning
Reaches SSW (ii)?	Yes
Japanese requirement	A2.2

The work. Making food. Production lines in factories that turn agricultural inputs into packaged products: sorting, preparation, cooking, filling, sealing, labelling, packing, and the hygiene and quality checks that surround all of it. Food-safety discipline is the core skill, and it is taught rather than assumed.

Who it suits. People who can hold a routine, work in a cold or warm environment for long shifts, follow hygiene rules without being reminded, and stand for eight hours. Experience in a food processing unit, a bakery, a commercial kitchen or a dairy is directly relevant.

The trade-off. It is the biggest field, which means the most employers, the most vacancies and the most competition from other nationalities. Vietnamese workers alone number 55,372 in this field. You will be entering a labour market where the recruiting pipelines are already built and pointed at other countries, which makes direct application harder than in a field where Indian candidates are scarce.

The hard part. Confirming that you can sit the skills test from India. It does not appear on the published India fee table, which usually means the test is arranged differently - in Japan, or through an employer's own assessment. Do not build a plan on an assumption here; ask the employer, in writing, how and where the test is administered.

If you choose it. Lead with hygiene and reliability in your CV and interview. Employers in this field are less interested in flair than in whether you will still be turning up in month thirty. If you have a food safety certificate, name it.

Industrial product manufacturing: the trade route

Field snapshot	Detail
Residents, June 2026	62,033
Three-year acceptance cap	199,500 places - the largest cap of any field
India skills-test fee	Rs 4,700
Reaches SSW (ii)?	Yes, but only in three sub-categories
Japanese requirement	A2.2

The work. Making components and assemblies in factories: machining, press work, welding, casting, surface treatment, electrical and electronic assembly, inspection. This is the field where an ITI or diploma converts most directly into a wage, because the skills test is measuring something you have already been doing.

Who it suits. Anyone with a manufacturing trade. Fitters, turners, welders, tool-and-die makers, electricians with panel experience, electronics assemblers. If you can read a drawing and hold a tolerance, this is your field.

Why the higher test fee is not the issue. Rs 4,700 sounds like a lot next to construction's Rs 684, but it is a one-time cost against a five-year wage in the field with the largest acceptance cap in the programme. If you have the trade, the fee is irrelevant. If you do not have the trade, the fee is not the reason you will fail.

The trap in the SSW (ii) pathway. Industrial product manufacturing reaches SSW (ii) only in three sub-categories: machining, electrical and electronic equipment assembly, and metal surface treatment. If long-term stay is your goal, confirm at contract stage which sub-category your job falls into, because a job outside those three is a five-year ceiling regardless of how good you are.

If you choose it. Bring your certificates and your drawings. In the interview, describe a specific job you made - the material, the tolerance, the machine - and you will be treated as a tradesman rather than an applicant.

Construction: the cheapest door, and a real career

Field snapshot	Detail
Residents, June 2026	52,132
Three-year acceptance cap	76,000 places
India skills-test fee	Rs 684 - the lowest of any field
Reaches SSW (ii)?	Yes
Japanese requirement	A2.2

The work. Building. Formwork, reinforcement, concreting, masonry, tiling, plastering, scaffolding, painting, and increasingly the machine operation and site coordination around them. Japanese sites are safety-obsessed and process-driven, which is either a relief or a shock depending on where you have worked.

Who it suits. Anyone with site experience and a working body. If you have done shuttering, bar bending, tiling or scaffolding in India, you have most of what the skills test asks for. The test costs Rs 684, which means you can attempt it without a financial decision.

Why it is genuinely underrated. Three reasons. It is on the SSW (ii) list, so the long-term path is open. The field has the longest history of accepting foreign workers, so the employers, the support organisations and the training infrastructure are the most developed in the programme. And the pay sits above the care and hospitality fields, because Japanese construction wages are higher.

The hard part. Heat, height and physical wear. Japanese summer on a site with full safety equipment is a serious physical demand, and it is the reason people leave in year two. Be honest with yourself in Chapter 7's question five. A worker who leaves at year two has spent the tests, the agent, the flight and two years of his life for nothing.

If you choose it. Say your trade precisely. "Shuttering carpenter, six years, residential and commercial" gets you a skills test booking and a wage conversation. "Construction worker" gets you a queue.

Agriculture and fishery: rural, seasonal, and quiet

Field snapshot	Detail
Residents, June 2026	44,050 in agriculture, 4,912 in fishery
Three-year acceptance cap	73,300 agriculture, 14,800 fishery
India skills-test fee	Rs 2,830 for agriculture, level 1
Reaches SSW (ii)?	Yes, both
Japanese requirement	A2.2

The work. Agriculture is planting, tending, harvesting and packing vegetables, fruit and flowers, plus livestock work with pigs, cattle and poultry. Fishery is catching and aquaculture - feeding, netting, sorting, processing, often on boats or at coastal facilities.

Who it suits. People from farming or fishing families, and people who genuinely prefer rural life. This is not a field to choose because it was the only test available.

The honest trade-off. Rural placements mean rural wages - agricultural minimum wages sit at the lower end - and rural life means you need Japanese more, not less, because there is no English-speaking community to fall back on. The compensation is that housing is often provided, living costs are low, and the saving rate can be better than a higher-paid city job where rent eats the difference.

Fishery specifically. Small field, few employers, and the work is weather-dependent and physically extreme. It is on the SSW (ii) list and has a genuine long-term pathway for people who come from that background. Do not enter it as a fallback.

If you choose it. Ask three questions before signing: is housing provided and at what deduction; how many hours a month in peak season; and how far is the nearest town with a hospital. The third one matters more than it sounds.

Accommodation and building cleaning: the service door

Field snapshot	Accommodation	Building cleaning
Residents, June 2026	2,556	10,171
Three-year acceptance cap	14,800	32,200
India skills-test fee	Rs 4,620	Not on the published India list
Reaches SSW (ii)?	Yes	Yes
Japanese requirement	A2.2	A2.2

Accommodation. Hotels and traditional inns: reception, guest services, restaurant service, housekeeping, and back-of-house work. Japanese hospitality standards are exacting and the language demand is high, because you are dealing with guests directly. The reward is that this is the most pleasant physical environment in the programme - indoors, climate controlled, and in places with a genuine training culture.

Building cleaning. Cleaning the interiors of office buildings, commercial premises and public facilities, including the operation of cleaning machinery and the management of cleaning schedules. It is technical work with chemical handling and equipment operation, not improvised sweeping, and Japanese cleaning firms take real pride in it.

The honest trade-off for both. These are the two fields where the gap between what the job sounds like and what it is creates the most disappointment. Cleaning is physically hard and starts early. Hotel work involves split shifts and a lot of standing. Neither is a soft option, and both pay at the lower end of the programme.

Where they win. Accommodation is a genuine route for people with hotel or restaurant experience, and the 2026 hospitality recruitment drives in India have been concentrated here - one government-published notice listed restaurant service and kitchen roles at JPY 183,000 to 190,000 gross per month. Building cleaning has a large cap (32,200) relative to its current population (10,171), which means it is genuinely under-subscribed and employers are actively recruiting.

If you choose either. Watch the food service field for the suspension lifting, since hotel and restaurant experience converts most easily there. In the meantime, accommodation is the closest open alternative.

PART EIGHT

Twelve months, one worksheet, and the questions everyone asks.

The twelve-month plan and the cost worksheet

This is the whole book as a schedule. Print it, put dates against it, and work backwards from the month you want to land in Japan.

Month	What you do	What it costs
1	Decide the field using Chapter 3's four filters. Start Japanese: kana in ten days, then daily vocabulary.	Nothing but time
2	Irodori A2, one lesson a day. Research employers in your field. Start assembling the document set in Chapter 14.	Nothing
3	Book the JFT-Basic on opening day. Timed sample tests weekly. Approach two or three employers directly.	Rs 3,540 when you book
4	Sit the JFT-Basic. Book the skills test for your field. Continue Japanese to B1 level if you want SSW (ii) later.	Skills test: Rs 684 to Rs 4,700
5	Sit the skills test. Interviews. Get the contract in writing and have it translated by your own translator.	Translation: a few thousand rupees
6	Contract signed. Employer files the Certificate of Eligibility application in Japan.	Nothing
7-8	Wait for the COE. Keep studying Japanese. Do not pay anyone to "expedite" anything.	Nothing
9	COE arrives. Apply for the visa through VFS.	Rs 500 visa fee plus VFS service fee
10	Visa issued. Book the flight. Confirm housing and the airport pickup in writing.	Flight cost
11	Land. Residence card, address registration, health insurance, bank account, phone, My Number.	Living costs
12	First payslip. Check it against Chapter 12's deduction table. If the deductions do not match what you were told, ask your support organisation in writing.	Nothing

Cost worksheet

Fill this in before you commit to anything. If the total is more than you can fund from savings, the plan is not ready - not the visa.

Item	Expected cost	Your figure
JFT-Basic test	Rs 3,540	
Skills test	Rs 684 to Rs 4,700	
Language classes, if any	Free to Rs 30,000	
Passport, if not held	Government fee	
Medical, if required	Varies	
Contract translation	A few thousand rupees	
Visa fee plus VFS service fee	Rs 500 plus VFS fee	
Registered agent, if used	Maximum Rs 35,400 with GST, receipt mandatory	
PBBY insurance, if via an agent	Rs 275 for two years, Rs 375 for three	
Flight	Varies by season	
First month's living costs in Japan	Fund before you go	
Total		

The one line to remember from this book

A legitimate route to Japan costs you a few tens of thousands of rupees and several months of study. A route that costs you two to eight lakh rupees is not a faster version of the same thing. It is a different thing.

Thirty questions, answered

Eligibility and the visa

1. Can I go to Japan on SSW with no Japanese at all? No. A2.2 equivalent is a condition of the visa, not a preference.

2. Is there an age limit? There is no age limit in the SSW regulations themselves, but employers set their own preferences and most hire in the twenties and early thirties. The average age of an SSW worker is 29.5.

3. Do I need a degree? No. You need a skills test pass and a language test pass. A degree is not required and does not substitute for either.

4. Can I bring my family? Not on SSW (i). Yes on SSW (ii), if requirements are met.

5. Can I change jobs? Yes, within your field, with notification to immigration. You cannot move to a different field without qualifying in it.

6. What happens after five years on SSW (i)? You either move to SSW (ii) by passing the higher skills test and meeting the language requirement, or you leave. There is no automatic extension.

7. Is SSW a path to permanent residence? Not directly. SSW (ii) allows indefinite renewal and dependants, which makes the ordinary permanent residence criteria reachable. SSW (i) does not.

Tests

8. Which Japanese test should I take? JFT-Basic, unless you already hold JLPT N4 or above.

9. What score do I need? 200 or above on the 10 to 250 scale, which is the A2.2 band.

10. Where can I take the JFT-Basic in India? Bengaluru, Gurgaon and Guwahati, at Prometric centres. Those are the only three.

11. How much does it cost? Rs 3,000 plus tax, which is Rs 3,540.

12. Can I get a refund if I fail or cannot attend? No. There is no cancellation. You may move the date up to three business days before, if seats are available.

13. How many people pass? In the August-September 2026 window in India, 33.6 per cent of candidates who sat the test reached A2.2.

14. Is the skills test hard? It is field-specific and practical. People with real trade experience pass it; people who have only read about the trade usually do not.

15. Can I take the skills test in India? For several fields yes - nursing care, construction, agriculture, accommodation and industrial product manufacturing all have published India fees. For others, confirm with the field's testing body before planning.

Money

16. How much will I earn? JPY 180,000 to 260,000 gross a month for a first job, depending on field, prefecture and overtime. The average for SSW workers was JPY 254,100 a month in the 2026 survey.

17. What is the minimum I can legally be paid? Your prefecture's minimum wage. The national weighted average for fiscal 2026 is JPY 1,177 per hour; Tokyo is JPY 1,280.

18. How much will actually arrive in my bank account? Roughly 82 per cent of gross in year one, and about 77 per cent from year two when resident tax starts.

19. How much can I save? Between JPY 45,000 and JPY 115,000 a month depending on housing and lifestyle. See Chapter 13.

20. Do I pay tax in India too? It depends on your residence status in India, which depends on days spent there. India and Japan have a tax treaty providing relief from double taxation. Ask a chartered accountant in

your first year abroad.

Agents and money

21. Do I need an agent? No. India's own embassy in Tokyo states that the use of a sending organisation is optional, and Japanese employers may contract with you directly.

22. What is the maximum a registered agent can charge me? Rs 30,000 plus 18 per cent GST, which is Rs 35,400, with a receipt.

23. An agent is asking for four lakh rupees. Is that normal? It is outside the legal cap by a factor of more than ten. The Ministry of External Affairs has issued a standing advisory about agents charging two to five lakh.

24. How do I check whether an agent is registered? Look up their licence number on emigrate.gov.in under "List of active RA". Every registered agent must display the number.

25. Should I pay a security deposit? No. Deposits and penalty contracts are prohibited in Japan's training programme, and a bond you repay for leaving early is a penalty by another name.

26. Is travel insurance mandatory? If you go through a registered recruiting agent, they must buy Pravasi Bharatiya Bima Yojana cover for you - Rs 275 for two years or Rs 375 for three, with a Rs 10 lakh sum assured. Ask for the policy.

The process

27. How long does the whole thing take? Nine to eighteen months, realistically. Language is three months, employer search two to five, the certificate of eligibility one to three.

28. What is a Certificate of Eligibility? A document immigration issues after examining the employer's application. It is not a visa. You still apply for the visa separately.

29. How much is the visa? Rs 500 for Indian nationals for a single or multiple entry visa, from 1 July 2026, plus the VFS service fee. The Embassy states that these are the only amounts payable for a visa.

30. Someone called claiming to be from the embassy and asked for money to verify my documents. Is that real? No. The Embassy of Japan in India states explicitly that it will never ask for payment over a telephone call or email to verify documents or expedite processing.

Appendix A: the official link directory

Everything in this book traces to one of these. Open them yourself before you spend money - they are free, they are authoritative, and no agent can argue with them.

What you need	Where it is
The SSW system in English: the 19 fields, status of residence, support obligations	ssw.go.jp/en/ - Immigration Services Agency of Japan
The law, the field list, the operational guidelines	moj.go.jp/isa/ - Immigration Services Agency, Japanese
Statistics: how many SSW workers, by nationality and field	moj.go.jp/isa/ - published twice a year, with field-level tables
Minimum wages by prefecture	mhlw.go.jp - regional minimum wage list, updated each autumn
Wages for foreign workers by visa type	mhlw.go.jp - Survey of Foreign Employment Status and the Basic Survey on Wage Structure
Social insurance rates	mhlw.go.jp - premium rates; and kyoukaikenpo.or.jp for prefectural health insurance rates
JFT-Basic: what it is, sample questions, results by country	jpf.go.jp/jft-basic/ - the Japan Foundation
JFT-Basic booking, centres, fees	prometric-jp.com - Prometric Japan
Skills test fees for India	prometric-jp.com/en/ssw/exam/fee/
Visa applications and fees for Indians	in.emb-japan.go.jp - Embassy of Japan in India; applications through VFS
Japan's guidance for employers hiring Indian SSW workers	indembassy-tokyo.gov.in - Embassy of India, Tokyo
India-Japan Action Plan on human resource exchange	mea.gov.in and pmindia.gov.in
Checking whether a recruiting agent is registered	emigrate.gov.in - "List of active RA"
Complaints against recruiting agents, and emigrant welfare	mea.gov.in/complaints-against-recruiting-agents; MADAD portal
Approved sending organisations for India	otit.go.jp - Organisation for Technical Intern Training
Skill India International Centres	nsdcindia.org and NSDC International

Appendix B: glossary

Term	What it means
A1 / A2.1 / A2.2 / B1	Levels on the Common European Framework scale for language ability. SSW (i) needs A2.2; SSW (ii) needs B1 from April 2027.
Certificate of Eligibility (COE)	A certificate immigration issues before the visa, confirming that your proposed activity and employer meet the criteria. Not a visa.
ESD (Employment for Skill Development)	Japan's new three-year training visa, replacing Technical Intern Training from 1 April 2027.
JFT-Basic	Japan Foundation Test for Basic Japanese. The language test built for this visa.
JLPT	Japanese Language Proficiency Test. N4 or above also satisfies the language requirement.
Kyokai Kenpo	Japan Health Insurance Association. The health insurer for most employees of small and medium firms; rates vary by prefecture.
My Number	Japan's national identification number, used for tax and social security.
PBBY	Pravasi Bharatiya Bima Yojana. Mandatory insurance that registered recruiting agents must buy for workers they send abroad.
PKVY	Pravasi Kaushal Vikas Yojana. India's pre-departure skilling and orientation programme for emigrant workers.
RA (Recruiting Agent)	An agent licensed by India's Ministry of External Affairs. Licence numbers are verifiable on emigrate.gov.in.
Registered Support Organisation	An organisation registered with the Immigration Services Agency to deliver the ten support obligations on an employer's behalf.
Residence card	Your Japanese ID, issued on arrival. You must carry it at all times.
Rirekisho	The standard Japanese resume format.
SIIC	Skill India International Centre. Government-run overseas employment preparation hub.
SSW (i) / SSW (ii)	The two grades of the Specified Skilled Worker visa. (i) is five years without family; (ii) allows indefinite renewal and dependants.
Standard monthly remuneration	The pay grade your health insurance and pension premiums are calculated on, rather than your exact salary.
TITP	Technical Intern Training Programme. Being replaced by ESD from April 2027; transitional rules keep existing interns going.
Resident tax	The local tax based on your previous year's income, starting in your second year in Japan. About 10 per cent.

Appendix C: sources

Every factual claim in this book traces to one of the following, all checked in November 2026. Where a figure came from a secondary report of an official statistic, the official statistic is named.

Japanese government

- Immigration Services Agency of Japan, Support Website for the Specified Skilled Worker Program - status of residence, the 19 fields, the ten support obligations.
- Immigration Services Agency, system overview of the foreign worker system (updated 29 September 2026) - field-level resident counts, acceptance ceilings, SSW (i) and (ii) conditions.
- Immigration Services Agency, statistics on the number of SSW residents (end-June 2026, provisional) and residence statistics for end-June 2026.
- Immigration Services Agency, Employment for Skill Development: system outline (revised July 2026) and operational guidelines (February 2026, amended April 2026).
- Immigration Services Agency, field-specific operational policies, cabinet decision of 23 January 2026 - the addition of linen supply, logistics warehousing and resource recycling.
- Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare, FY2026 regional minimum wage decisions (3 September 2026) and the national prefectural table.
- Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare, Survey of Foreign Employment Status 2026 (published 31 August 2026) and Basic Survey on Wage Structure 2025 (published 24 March 2026).
- Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare, social insurance premium rates and the 2026 take-home pay illustration page.
- Organisation for Technical Intern Training, list of approved sending organisations for India, and guidance on the transition to Employment for Skill Development.

Test administrators

- The Japan Foundation, JFT-Basic official site and sample questions; implementation report for the August-September 2026 test window (India results); press release 2026-016 of 3 August 2026 on the A1, A2.1 and A2.2 scoring bands.
- Prometric Japan, examination fees by country (India section), test list and booking notices.

Indian government

- Ministry of External Affairs, Action Plan for India-Japan Human Resource Exchange and Cooperation, 29 August 2025.
- Ministry of External Affairs, advisory on overcharging by agents for overseas recruitment, and guidance on complaints against recruiting agents.
- Ministry of External Affairs, Lok Sabha unstarred question 3621, answered 13 March 2026 - Skill India International Centres and Pravasi Kaushal Vikas Yojana.
- Embassy of India, Tokyo - guidance for SSW accepting organisations and the SSW information page.
- NSDC and NSDC International - Skill India International Centres and Japanese Language Training Centres.
- State government publication of an NSDC International hospitality SSW placement notice (gross monthly wage for restaurant and kitchen roles).

Embassy of Japan in India

- Visa page - fee for Indian nationals from 1 July 2026, VFS submission, and the fraud warning about payment requests by telephone or email.

A closing note. This book was written to be used, not admired. If you take one action from it, take the one that costs the least and matters the most: open ssw.go.jp, find your field, and confirm it is open today. Everything

else follows from that page, and nobody can sell you a version of it that is not true.